Site first look: the one-hour desktop check before you offer

For landowners, small developers and investors looking at a site for new homes in England · free public maps and registers, about 60 minutes

Written by blng studio · Checked on 28 October 2026

You need the address, a rough red line and an hour. Work through the steps in order and mark each line **G** (no issue found), **A** (needs a closer look) or **R** (could stop or reshape the scheme). This is a first look from public sources, not a feasibility study: it tells you which questions to answer before you offer.

Where to look: HM Land Registry (GOV.UK ‘Search property information’) for the title; the council's planning register and local plan; planning.data.gov.uk for conservation areas, listed building outlines, Article 4 direction areas, tree preservation zones, Green Belt and flood risk zones (if your council's data isn't there, use the council's own maps); Historic England's National Heritage List for England; the Environment Agency's Flood map for planning; and Defra's MAGIC map for protected sites and habitats.

Site address	
Site area (ha)	
Council	
What you want to test	

1. The site and its history · 10 min

1	**Title:** download the title register and plan. Does the boundary match your red line? Note rights of way, easements and restrictive covenants for your solicitor.	☐ G ☐ A ☐ R
2	**Site area:** measure the area inside your red line in hectares. You will need it for the 0.2 ha, 0.5 ha and 1 ha thresholds below.	☐ G ☐ A ☐ R
3	**Planning history:** search the council's planning register for the site and its neighbours: approvals, refusals and the reasons, and conditions still in force.	☐ G ☐ A ☐ R

2. Constraints on the map · 15 min

4	**Conservation area?** Councils designate areas whose character or appearance it is desirable to preserve or enhance (Planning (Listed Buildings and Conservation Areas) Act 1990, s 69). Expect closer scrutiny of demolition and design.	☐ G ☐ A ☐ R
5	**Listed building** on or next to the site? Works affecting a listed building's character need listed building consent (same Act, s 7), and the setting of nearby heritage assets matters (NPPF, chapter 20).	☐ G ☐ A ☐ R
6	**Protected trees?** Check for tree preservation orders (TCPA 1990, s 198) and plan for a tree survey.	☐ G ☐ A ☐ R
7	**Green Belt?** Inappropriate development should not be approved except in very special circumstances; some grey belt and previously developed land is treated differently (NPPF, policies GB6 and GB7).	☐ G ☐ A ☐ R
8	**Flood zone:** in Flood Zones 2, 3a and 3b every proposal needs a site-specific flood risk assessment; in Flood Zone 1, sites of 1 ha or more do too. The sequential test may also apply (NPPF, policies F4 and F5).	☐ G ☐ A ☐ R
9	**Protected landscape or wildlife site?** Check MAGIC for a Site of Special Scientific Interest or a National Landscape (designated as an area of outstanding natural beauty under the Countryside and Rights of Way Act 2000, s 82).	☐ G ☐ A ☐ R

3. The planning route · 15 min

10	**How big is it?** Major development means 10 or more homes or a site of 0.5 ha or more (NPPF, Annex B). The council then has 13 weeks to decide instead of 8 (Development Management Procedure Order 2015, art 34).	☐ G ☐ A ☐ R
11	**Permitted development?** Class MA allows some Class E buildings to become homes after prior approval, if the building has been in Class E use for at least 2 continuous years and is not, for example, listed, in a Site of Special Scientific Interest or in a National Landscape (GPDO 2015, Sch 2, Part 3). Part 20 covers some new homes on top of existing buildings. An Article 4 direction can remove these rights (GPDO 2015, art 4).	☐ G ☐ A ☐ R
12	**Permission in principle?** For housing-led sites, this two-stage route settles whether the site is suitable in principle before the technical details (GOV.UK planning guidance, 'Permission in principle').	☐ G ☐ A ☐ R
13	**Talk to the council early:** the NPPF expects pre-application engagement, proportionate to the proposal (policy DM1). Note whether the council offers pre-application advice.	☐ G ☐ A ☐ R

4. Height and fire (flats) · 5 min

14	**Top storey more than 11 m** above ground: sprinklers throughout (Approved Document B, Volume 1, 2019 edition incorporating 2026 amendments, para 7.4). A single stair is only an option up to 11 m and no more than three storeys above the ground storey (para 3.32).	☐ G ☐ A ☐ R
15	**Top storey 18 m or more:** more than one common stair (para 3.30). At 18 m or 7 storeys with 2 or more homes, the building is higher-risk (Building Safety Act 2022, s 65): the planning application needs a fire statement (DMPO 2015, art 9A), and building control approval comes from the Building Safety Regulator before work starts.	☐ G ☐ A ☐ R

5. Nature and biodiversity net gain · 5 min

16	**Biodiversity net gain** of 10% is mandatory unless the development is exempt (TCPA 1990, Sch 7A). Exemptions include sites of 0.2 ha or below inside the red line (applications from 6 August 2026), development affecting less than 25 m² of habitat or 5 m of hedgerow, householder applications and temporary permissions of 5 years or less. The self-build exemption ended for applications made on or after 6 August 2026. If priority habitat on the site is affected, the 0.2 ha, 25 m² and temporary exemptions do not apply (GOV.UK, 'Biodiversity net gain: exempt developments').	☐ G ☐ A ☐ R

6. Homes standards and charges · 5 min

17	**Space and access standards:** does the local plan require the Nationally Described Space Standard, or accessible homes to M4(2) or M4(3) (Approved Document M, Volume 1)? Both change how many homes fit.	☐ G ☐ A ☐ R
18	**Community Infrastructure Levy:** does the council charge it? Most development that creates a new home, or 100 m² or more of new floor space, is potentially liable. Check the charging schedule (GOV.UK, 'Community Infrastructure Levy').	☐ G ☐ A ☐ R

Score it (5 min). Count your Rs and As. An R is not a no: it is the question to answer first. Several As on the same theme, such as heritage or flooding, usually add up to one big question. Write your top three questions down before you talk to the agent or make an offer.

Question 1	
Question 2	
Question 3	

Now test the options

Your first look tells you what to ask. The **Feasibility Sprint** answers it: a site visit, a planning policy and history review, a constraints map, three massing options with an area schedule, and a red, amber or green planning risk rating for each option. sprint.blng.studio/sprints/feasibility-sprint/

General guidance for England, checked against official sources on 28 October 2026. It is not advice on a specific site, a valuation or legal advice. Policies and thresholds change: check the current versions and your council's local plan.

Sources: NPPF (17 August 2026, gov.uk); Planning (Listed Buildings and Conservation Areas) Act 1990, ss 7 and 69; TCPA 1990, s 198 and Sch 7A; Countryside and Rights of Way Act 2000, s 82; Town and Country Planning (Development Management Procedure) (England) Order 2015, arts 9A and 34; Town and Country Planning (General Permitted Development) (England) Order 2015, art 4 and Sch 2 Parts 3 and 20; Building Safety Act 2022, s 65 (legislation.gov.uk); Approved Documents B (Volume 1) and M (Volume 1); GOV.UK guidance on permission in principle, biodiversity net gain, the Community Infrastructure Levy, the Nationally Described Space Standard and building control approval for higher-risk buildings.